

YPRES 1914–1918

Tour Leader Field Companion · Site Scripts, Topography & Parish Remembrance



The War Memorial Lychgate & Shelter at Holy Rood Church, Stubbington — Anchoring our school expedition to our local parish fallen who lie in the Salient.

THE STUBBINGTON WAR MEMORIAL · PARISH BEREAVEMENT & FLANDERS MEMORY

Erected in 1922 on the village green over the historic parish water pump, the Stubbington War Memorial Shelter stands as a unique community tribute to the sixty-seven local men and women who gave their lives in the Great War. Designed not as a cold, distant stone obelisk but as an active shelter for daily village life, it directly anchors our school fieldwork to the bereavement and sacrifice of our home community.

LOCAL PARISH FALLEN COMMEMORATED IN THE SALIENT & VISITED ON OUR TOUR

Tracing Individual Graves & Memorial Panels

LOCAL SOLDIER	REGIMENT & LOCAL CONNECTION	SALIENT MEMORIAL LOCATION & ACTION
Pte. Thomas J. Franklin	1st Bn, Hampshire Regt (Age 23) Meadow Cottage, Chark	Menin Gate · Panel 35 Killed 29 April 1915, Second Ypres (Frezenberg Ridge)
Pte. William Ayling	1st Bn, Hampshire Regt (Age 20) Stubbington Lane; Baker Boy	Menin Gate · Panel 35 Killed 9 July 1915, trench mortar bombardment at Potijze
Pte. Sydney Muckett	15th Bn, Hampshire Regt (Age 21) Parish of Crofton / Holy Rood	Tyne Cot · Panels 88–90 Killed 20 Sept 1917, Battle of Menin Road Ridge
Pte. Arthur Rye	14th Bn, Hampshire Regt (Age 21) Parish of Crofton / Holy Rood	Tyne Cot · Panels 88–90 Killed 26 Sept 1917, Battle of Polygon Wood
L/Cpl. Archibald Ward	15th Bn, Hampshire Regt (Age 23) Parish of Crofton / Holy Rood	Tyne Cot · Panels 88–90 Killed 14 Oct 1918, Gheluwe advance in dawn mist
Pte. Charles Warland	3rd/4th The Queen's (Age 20) Parish of Crofton / Holy Rood	Tyne Cot · Panels 14–17 Killed 4 Oct 1917, Battle of Broodseinde
The Lowry Brothers	William (25), Cyril (20), Eric (25) Manor Way Grange, Lee-on-the-Solent	Crofton Parish Memorial Tablet Three brothers killed across Gallipoli, the Somme & Arras

*“They shall grow not old, as we that are left grow old:
Age shall not weary them, nor the years condemn.
At the going down of the sun and in the morning,
We will remember them.”*

— LAURENCE BINYON · FOR THE FALLEN (1914) —

EXPEDITION ITINERARY & SALIENT MAP

Tour Leader Route Pacing & 13 Historic Field Stops

MASTER TIMETABLE

13 Historic Stops



Strategic Overview of the Ypres Salient (1914–1918): Showing frontlines, allied defense arcs, and all 13 field expedition study stops.

TIME	SITE / LOCATION	TOUR LEADER GUIDANCE & PEDAGOGICAL OBJECTIVE
D1 • 06:15	Depart / Folkestone	Coach departure; passports checked; 11:20 Eurotunnel; arrival in Flanders.
D1 • 14:30	Stop 1: Essex Farm ADS	Bunker 4 triage; Alexis Helmer burial; recite <i>In Flanders Fields</i> ; Pte. Strudwick (15 yrs).
D1 • 15:15	Stop 2: Yorkshire Trench	Canal bank breastworks, A-frames, deep dugout entrance, phosgene gas attack.
D1 • 16:00	Stop 3: Langemarck Cemetery	<i>Kindermord</i> myth; Kameradengrab (24,917); Emil Krieger mourners; German contrast.
D1 • 17:00	Stop 4: Hooge Crater Museum	19 July 1915 mine blast (120ft crater); 30 July flamethrower debut; authentic weaponry.
D1 • 18:00	Peace Village Base Camp	Room check-in, 18:30 evening dinner, 19:30 seminar room debrief and day synthesis.
D2 • 09:15	Stop 5: Vancouver Corner	First lethal gas attack (22 April 1915); Canadian stand; urine cloth defense; Brooding Soldier.
D2 • 10:00	Stop 6: Sanctuary Wood	Preserved British frontline trenches, traverses, mud, duckboard sumps, trench rats.
D2 • 11:45	Lunch Stop (Aldi, Ypres)	Supervised shopping for fresh picnic lunches, fruit, and snacks in town centre.
D2 • 13:00	Stop 7: Tyne Cot Cemetery	11,961 graves (70% unknown); Baker pillbox cross; missing wall (34,984 names); local boys.
D2 • 14:30	Stop 8: Lijssenthoek Cemetery	Casualty Clearing Station chain; 300,000 wounded; Staff Nurse Nellie Spindler (Plot XVI).
D2 • 16:00	Stop 9: Passchendaele Museum	Subterranean dugouts 20ft deep; living bunks; reconstructed British & German trenches.
D2 • 19:20	Stop 10: Menin Gate Last Post	Wreath laying; Panel 35 (Franklin & Ayling); volunteer Fire Brigade buglers at 20:00.
D3 • 09:30	Stop 11: Ypres Cloth Hall	Grote Markt; stone-by-stone reconstruction; civilian rebirth; Belgian artisan chocolate.
D3 • 10:45	Stop 12: Talbot House	Tubby Clayton; Everyman sanctuary; Upper Room hop-loft chapel; carpenter's altar; library.
D3 • 12:45	Stop 13: Poperinge Death Cells	Town Hall courtyard execution post; military justice; 306 shot at dawn; 2006 statutory pardon.
D3 • 14:30	Calais Transit & Return	Depart Poperinge for Calais; 17:50 Le Shuttle crossing; arrive at school approx 20:00.

THE FLEMISH CLAY BASIN & RIDGE TOPOGRAPHY

"Look out over the landscape: Flanders appears dead flat, but the Salient is defined by a low, curved clay ridge rising barely 45 metres towards Passchendaele. In 1914, German forces seized that higher ground, wrapping around Ypres on three sides. This formed 'the Salient'—a murderous bulge where German artillery could fire inwards from north, east, and south. The soil beneath our feet is dense, water-impermeable Flemish blue clay. When millions of artillery shells shattered the medieval drainage dykes, the trapped groundwater had nowhere to go, turning the entire battleground into an ocean of liquid mud where men, mules, and guns literally drowned."



CWGC Portland Stone Dimensions: 81cm high × 38cm wide × 7.5cm thick.

- 1. Regimental Badge:** Identical size for privates and generals (absolute equality in death).
- 2. Service Details:** Number, rank, name, honours, battalion, regiment.
- 3. Religious Emblem:** Latin Cross, Star of David, or left blank for secular/unaffiliated.
- 4. Date of Death & Age:** Average age across the Salient was just 24 years.
- 5. Personal Inscription:** Family-chosen (max 66 characters; 3½d per letter).
- 6. Unknown Dead:** Rudyard Kipling's universal words: "A Soldier of the Great War — Known unto God."

SIR FABIAN WARE'S FOUNDING PHILOSOPHY

In 1917, Red Cross commander Sir Fabian Ware established the Imperial War Graves Commission with three radical, non-negotiable principles:

- 1. Radical Equality:** Every soldier, whether field marshal or teenage private, receives an identical Portland headstone. No family could purchase an elaborate marble mausoleum.
- 2. No Repatriation:** The British government strictly forbade the repatriation of corpses to Britain. Wealthy families could not bring their sons home while others grieved abroad.
- 3. Permanence & Identity:** Each grave is maintained in perpetuity, set within perennial English cottage gardens symbolizing rebirth amidst destruction.

DECIPHERING FAMILY INSCRIPTION TYPOLOGIES

Have pupils inspect headstones and categorize family epitaphs into four distinct emotional registers:

- **Christian Resignation & Faith:** "Thy Will Be Done" · "Until The Day Break And The Shadows Flee Away"
- **Classical Duty & Patriotism:** "For King And Country" · "He Died That We Might Live In Peace"
- **Raw Personal Grief:** "A Day Of Memory Sad To Recall, Without Goodbye He Left Us All" · "Our Only Son"
- **Stoic Pride & Quiet Honour:** "Duty Nobly Done" · "He Played The Game To The Very End"

"Why did Fabian Ware insist on uniform Portland stone and ban wealthy families from repatriating bodies, yet allow families to choose and pay for a private inscription? Does this preserve equality or reintroduce class differences?"

THE LOWRY FAMILY TRAGEDY: MANOR WAY GRANGE & THREE FALLEN SONS

"Stand with pupils and share this extraordinary local story: William and Annie Lowry lived at Manor Way Grange in Lee-on-the-Solent. They had three sons—William, Cyril, and Eric. In 1914, all three volunteered and took officer commissions. Over the next four years, all three were killed in action across different theaters. William died in a charge at Gallipoli; Cyril was shot dead on the Somme right in front of his brother Eric's eyes; and Eric, a decorated Lieutenant Colonel with a DSO and MC, was killed inspecting frontline outposts near Arras in the final weeks of the war in 1918. Their grief-stricken father built the Lowry Memorial Hall in Lee-on-the-Solent so their names would never fade. On our Holy Rood memorial tablet, all three are reunited."



Lieut. William Lowry
8th Gurkha Rifles (Age 25)

Killed 4 June 1915 during the third battle of Krithia, Gallipoli; commemorated on Helles Memorial.



Lieutenant C. J. P. Lowry

Capt. Cyril Lowry
2nd West Yorks (Age 20)

Killed 25 Mar 1918, German Spring Offensive on the Somme in front of Eric. Pozieres Memorial.



Captain A. E. E. Lowry

Lt. Col. Eric Lowry DSO MC
2nd West Yorks (Age 25)

Killed 23 Sep 1918, Arras outpost trench inspection just weeks before the Armistice. La Targette Cemetery.

THE LOWRY MEMORIAL HALL & THE ANATOMY OF PARISH MOURNING

The loss of all three sons destroyed the Lowry household. In response to his unbearable grief, their father William Lowry purchased land on Marine Parade in Lee-on-the-Solent and funded the construction of the **Lowry Memorial Hall** as a permanent civic and social gift to the village, ensuring their sacrifice served future generations of local children.

Inside Holy Rood Church in Crofton parish, a dedicated brass tablet reunites William, Cyril, and Eric. When pupils study the Western Front, the Lowry tragedy serves as an essential bridge: proving that the catastrophic British casualty statistics (over 700,000 dead) were experienced as acute, devastating trauma in individual homes and coastal lanes right on our doorstep.

FIELDWORK ENQUIRY: CONNECTING LOCAL PARISH MEMORIALS TO THE FLANDERS SALIENT

Discuss with pupils the vital contrast between a village war memorial (like the wooden shelter in Stubbington or the hall in Lee-on-the-Solent) and the massive imperial memorials they will witness in Flanders (such as the Menin Gate with 54,000 names or Tyne Cot with 35,000 missing). Have students consider how individual family memory survived amidst industrialized mass slaughter.

"How does discovering that three brothers from one coastal family in our local village were wiped out transform our understanding of the 'Lost Generation' from abstract textbook statistics into acute personal grief?"

THE STORY TO TELL AT ESSEX FARM

"We are standing outside the concrete medical bunkers carved directly into the Yser Canal bank. In May 1915, during the ferocious Second Battle of Ypres, Dr John McCrae of the Canadian Army Medical Corps worked inside these damp, dark, blood-soaked chambers triaging thousands of casualties blinded and choking from poison gas. On 2 May, an 8-inch high-explosive shell scored a direct hit on his 22-year-old friend and former student, Lieutenant Alexis Helmer, blowing him to pieces. With no chaplain available, McCrae gathered what remained of Helmer in a blanket and buried him at night by lantern light, reciting the prayers by memory. Early the next morning, sitting on the rear step of an ambulance looking out over this bank, McCrae saw wild red field poppies flourishing across the fresh, shell-churned graves—and penned the world's most famous war poem."

CASE STUDY: PRIVATE VALENTINE STRUDWICK (PLOT I. U. 8)

Enlisted at age 14 after lying about his age; sent to Flanders with the 8th Rifle Brigade. Killed in action on 14 January 1916 aged just **15 years and 11 months**—one of the youngest British casualties on the Western Front. Point out his mother's moving epitaph: *"Not gone from memory, not gone from love, but gone to our Father's home above."* Notice the continuous carpet of school poppy crosses left by visiting children.

MEDICAL EVACUATION CHAIN AT ESSEX FARM

An Advanced Dressing Station (ADS) was the second tier of the evacuation chain, positioned 1–2 miles behind the front line. Stretcher bearers brought wounded from battalion Regimental Aid Posts (RAPs). Doctors performed emergency triage: bandaging, morphine injections, anti-tetanus serum, and limb splinting before moving patients by motor ambulance to Casualty Clearing Stations (CCS).

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **Bunker 4 Triage Arch:** Examine the low, damp concrete vaults built into the canal earthwork to shield surgeons and wounded from artillery enfilade.
- **Grave of Valentine Strudwick (Plot I. U. 8):** Observe the headstone age ('15') and compare with surrounding comrades in their twenties and thirties.
- **Yser Canal Embankment Ridge:** Look at the steep canal bank offering the only natural shielding from German artillery observation on the eastern ridges.
- **Memorial Obelisk to John McCrae:** The bronze plaque quoting the poem overlooking the canal where Alexis Helmer was buried in the dark.

TOUR LEADER FIELD NOTE: GATHERING AT BUNKER 4

Gather the party outside Bunker 4 where John McCrae operated. Explain how wounded were carried down the canal bank under artillery fire before directing pupils to locate Valentine Strudwick's headstone. Proceed to the bronze McCrae memorial obelisk for the reading on the facing page.

In Flanders Fields • LT. COL. JOHN MCCRAE (CANADIAN AMC) • 3 MAY 1915



*In Flanders fields the poppies blow
Between the crosses, row on row,
That mark our place; and in the sky
The larks, still bravely singing, fly
Scarce heard amid the guns below.*

*We are the Dead. Short days ago
We lived, felt dawn, saw sunset glow,
Loved and were loved, and now we lie,
In Flanders fields.*

*Take up our quarrel with the foe:
To you from failing hands we throw
The torch; be yours to hold it high.
If ye break faith with us who die
We shall not sleep, though poppies grow
In Flanders fields.*

The Red Poppy & Recruitment Symbolism:

Written on the back step of a field ambulance after McCrae buried his young friend Alexis Helmer, the poem personifies the dead speaking directly to the living.

While the first two stanzas lament the loss of young life in the mud, the final stanza shifts sharply to military defiance. It was swiftly seized upon by Allied governments across Britain, Canada, and the Commonwealth to drive enlistment campaigns, demanding that fresh waves of young recruits take up the torch against the foe.

1. "How did McCrae's poem transform a common weed growing in disturbed agricultural soil into a sacred global symbol of remembrance—and does the final stanza glorify continuous warfare?"
2. "What does Valentine Strudwick's grave reveal about the effectiveness of British Army enlistment age checks during the recruiting rush of 1914–15?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** Reboard coach for a 10-minute drive north-east along the Diksmuidseweg to Yorkshire Trench (Boezinge).

THE DISCOVERY OF YORKSHIRE TRENCH

"This site was completely lost to history for 75 years until 1992, when an amateur Belgian archaeological team known as 'The Diggers' investigated land slated for industrial development. Beneath the undisturbed topsoil, they uncovered an intact British frontline system constructed in 1915 by the 49th (West Riding) Division. As you walk through, notice that trenches here were not dug deep into the earth, but built upwards as raised sandbag breastworks. In the low Yser valley, digging down just three feet hits groundwater. Men lived with stagnant water pooling around their boots 24 hours a day. Notice the steel-reinforced entrances leading down to deep subterranean dugouts 30 feet beneath us, where over 200 soldiers huddled in candlelit bunks waiting for the order to go over the top."



British infantry manning frontline breastworks: Sandbag revetments, timber A-frames, and wooden duckboards laid above Flemish groundwater.

TRENCH ARCHITECTURE & TRAVERSES

Trenches were never straight lines; they followed a rigid 90-degree zig-zag pattern. These earth baffles, called **traverses**, prevented enemy raiders from firing enfilade down the trench line and contained high-explosive shell blast fragments to a single fire bay. Sump drainage channels beneath the duckboards channeled standing water away.

THE PHOSGENE GAS ATTACK (19 DEC 1915)

This sector saw the German military debut of **phosgene gas**, mixed with chlorine to create an invisible cloud. Colorless and smelling faintly of moldy hay, phosgene was six times deadlier than chlorine. Its suffocating fluid buildup in the lungs took 24 to 48 hours to manifest, catching unwary troops off guard.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **Preserved Timber A-Frames:** Look beneath the duckboards to see the inverted V-shaped wooden posts holding up trench walls.
- **Subterranean Dugout Stairwells:** The steep timber-lined shafts descending 30 feet into the earth, where 200 men sheltered from bombardments.
- **Sandbag Breastwork Elevation:** Notice how the trench walls rise above ground level using revetments because digging deeper struck water.
- **Firestep Construction:** The raised wooden ledge allowing riflemen to step up, fire over the parapet into No Man's Land, and step down to cover.

1. "Looking at the high water table and cramped zig-zag walls, did soldiers in the Salient face a greater daily threat from enemy artillery or from the hostile Flemish environment itself?"

2. "Why was the discovery of Yorkshire Trench by amateur archaeologists so vital in transforming our understanding of physical trench construction versus idealized textbook diagrams?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 15-minute coach transit north-east along the N313 to Langemarck German Military Cemetery.

THE MYTH OF THE KINDERMORD

"Step through the heavy red granite blockhouse and notice the instant, somber change of atmosphere: dark oak trees, flat black basalt slabs lying flush with the lawn, and no white Portland crosses. This is Langemarck, known across Germany as the *Studentenfriedhof* ('Student Cemetery'). In October 1914, during the First Battle of Ypres, thousands of idealistic German schoolboy and university volunteers were thrown into battle here with barely six weeks of drill. German wartime propaganda claimed they linked arms and charged singing the *Deutschlandlied* ('Song of Germany') before being mown down by experienced British regular rifle fire in what became mythologized as the *Kindermord bei Ypern* ('Massacre of the Innocents'). In June 1940, Adolf Hitler—who fought here as a corporal in the 16th Bavarian Reserve Regiment—visited this site to exploit the dead for Nazi propaganda."

ARCHITECTURAL & THEOLOGICAL CONTRAST

Unlike the luminous, hopeful white Portland stone and manicured flower borders of British CWGC cemeteries, German memorial philosophy under the *Volksbund Deutsche Kriegsgräberfürsorge* is austere, melancholic, and deeply rooted in Germanic forest romanticism. Over 44,000 soldiers lie buried in this small compound—nearly four times the density of Tyne Cot.

THE KAMERADENGRAB (COMRADES' GRAVE)

Immediately past the entrance lies the *Kameradengrab*—a single mass grave containing the remains of **24,917 German soldiers** whose bodies could not be individually identified. Bronze panels surrounding the plot record thousands of names alphabetically, including flying ace Werner Voss and young university students from Munich, Heidelberg, and Berlin.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **The Kameradengrab Bronze Wall:** Trace the perimeter panels surrounding the central mass grave of 24,917 unidentified soldiers.
- **Flat Basalt Group Slabs:** Notice that each small basalt ground slab marks the resting place of up to 20 soldiers lying together beneath the lawn.
- **Emil Krieger Mourning Bronzes:** The four life-sized silhouette bronze soldiers standing at the cemetery's rear, their heads bowed in eternal grief.
- **Preserved German Pillbox Concrete:** Three reinforced concrete pillboxes from the 1917 Langemarck Gneisenau line integrated into the perimeter.

TOUR LEADER FIELD DIRECTIVE: SILENCE & CONTRAST

Lead pupils along the oak pathway to the bronze mourners. Emphasize that here lies the grief of the defeated nation. Have students reflect on how mass burials shaped postwar German psychology before proceeding to the poetry reading on the facing page.

When You See Millions of the Mouthless Dead • CHARLES HAMILTON SORLEY (KILLED AT LOOS, OCT 1915, AGE 20)



*When you see millions of the mouthless dead
Across your dreams in pale battalions go,
Say not soft things as other men have said,
That you'll remember. For you need not so.
Give them not praise. For, deaf, how should they know
It is not curses heaped on each gashed head?
Nor tears. Their blind eyes see not your tears flow.
Nor honour. It is easy to be dead.
Say only this, "They are dead." Then add thereto,
"Yet many a better one has died than you."*

The Refusal of Sentimentalism:

Discovered in Sorley's field kit after he was killed in action at Loos aged just 20, this austere, unflinching sonnet refuses to sanitize industrial slaughter with conventional platitudes of glory, sacrifice, or posthumous honour.

Standing at Langemarck before the 25,000 unidentified dead in the single mass *Kameradengrab*, Sorley's words demand that we confront the absolute finality and senselessness of modern technological warfare.

1. "Why did the German state choose dark basalt, mass graves, and somber oak trees rather than individual white headstones? How does this reflect differing national psychologies of grief between victor and vanquished?"
2. "How does Charles Sorley's poem dismantle patriotic war rhetoric when read standing before 25,000 unidentified German dead in the Kameradengrab?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 20-minute coach transit south-east around the Ypres ring road to Hooge Crater Museum on the Menin Road.

THE MENIN ROAD BLOODBATH

"We are standing on the infamous Menin Road, the single most dangerous highway in military history. Hooze Chateau, positioned on a low crest commanding the road into Ypres, changed hands dozens of times in savage hand-to-hand fighting. On 19 July 1915, British tunnelling companies detonated a massive subterranean mine packed with 1,700 pounds of ammonal directly beneath German positions, blowing a crater 120 feet wide and 20 feet deep. Eleven days later, on 30 July, the German army struck back with terrifying shock technology: the world debut of the *Flammenwerfer* (flamethrower). German shock-troops sprayed jets of burning oil over the British parapets, incinerating men alive and capturing the crater rim. The museum houses an unrivaled collection of authentic weapons, trench armor, and primary battlefield artifacts recovered from these fields."



The Hooze Crater basin and reconstructed trenches: Scene of the 19 July 1915 mine blast and first liquid flame attack.

SUBTERRANEAN MINE WARFARE

When surface assaults stalled against machine guns, both armies burrowed deep underground. Specialist miners ('clay kickers') dug silent shafts through clay to detonate ammonal charges, sparking savage 'crater fights' to seize the lip.

EVENING ROUTINE AT PEACE VILLAGE

Following Hooze, the coach transfers directly to Peace Village Hostel in Mesen (18:00 check-in). After dinner at 18:30, tour leaders convene in the seminar room at 19:30 for a 45-minute debrief and fieldwork review.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **The Preserved Crater Depression:** Walk the perimeter path of the water-filled mine crater behind the museum.
- **Museum Trench Armor Collection:** Examine the heavy steel *Grabenpanzer* breastplates worn by sentries.
- **Reconstructed Frontline Firebays:** Step through preserved trenches behind the museum to inspect wooden revetments.
- **Original Battlefield Periscopes:** View optical mirrors allowing sentries to observe No Man's Land safely.

1. "Why did both armies invest vast manpower in subterranean mine warfare rather than surface infantry assaults? What does this reveal about defensive technology?"
2. "Did the introduction of the flamethrower at Hooze alter the moral boundary of civilized warfare, or was it an extension of industrial artillery terror?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 25-minute coach transit south along the N365 to Peace Village Base Camp, Nieuwkerkestraat 9, Mesen.

22 APRIL 1915 — THE FIRST LETHAL GAS CLOUD

"Stand looking north-east across this flat, open farmland. On the afternoon of 22 April 1915, at exactly 17:00, German engineers opened the valves on 5,730 pressurized steel cylinders buried along a four-mile frontline, releasing 168 tons of liquified **chlorine gas**. Carried by a gentle north-easterly breeze, a sinister greenish-yellow cloud rolled across No Man's Land toward the French Algerian and territorial division on the Canadian left. Unprepared and without respirators, soldiers suffocated as chlorine dissolved their lung tissue. Thousands broke in absolute panic, opening a four-mile gap in the Allied line. The raw, untested 1st Canadian Division held the right flank. Canadian medical officer Captain Francis Scrimger VC recognized the gas as chlorine and ordered men to urinate on handkerchiefs and socks, pressing them to their faces—ammonia in urine neutralized the acid. For three desperate days, the Canadians held the line, preventing the collapse of Ypres."



The Brooding Soldier Memorial (Frederick Clemesha): 33-foot granite monolith honoring 2,000 Canadians who fell holding the line against chlorine gas.

PHYSIOLOGY OF CHLORINE POISONING

Chlorine gas is 2.5 times denser than air; it hugged the ground depressions and rolled down into firebays. Inhaled, it reacted with water in the lungs to produce hydrochloric acid, destroying lung alveoli and causing drowning in internal secretions within minutes.

EVOLUTION OF BRITISH GAS DEFENSE

Improvised urine cloths quickly gave way to the 'Black Veil' pad (soaked in sodium thiosulfate), followed by the flannel 'Hypo Helmet' (1915), the Phenate Hexamine helmet, and finally the 1916 Small Box Respirator (SBR) using active coconut charcoal filters.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **Clemesha's 33-Foot Granite Monolith:** Notice the Canadian soldier's head bowed over arms rested on his reversed rifle in mourning posture.
- **Canadian Red Cedar & Maple Gardens:** The formal geometric park planting brought over from Canada to surround their fallen sons.
- **Directional Battle Direction Arrows:** Stone plaques indicating the direction of the German gas release and Canadian counter-attacks.
- **Flat Open Farmland Vista:** Notice the absence of high ground—explaining why poison gas drifted unimpeded across the salient.

TOUR LEADER FIELD DIRECTIVE: THE CANADIAN LINE

Gather pupils at the base of the monument. Point north-east toward Poelcappelle to trace the path of the gas cloud before opening the Owen reading on the facing page.

Dulce et Decorum Est • WILFRED OWEN (WRITTEN AT CRAIGLOCKHART, 1917)



*Gas! GAS! Quick, boys!—An ecstasy of fumbling,
Fitting the clumsy helmets just in time;
But someone still was yelling out and stumbling,
And flound'ring like a man in fire or lime...
Dim, through the misty panes and thick green light,
As under a green sea, I saw him drowning.*

*In all my dreams, before my helpless sight,
He plunges at me, guttering, choking, drowning.*

*If in some smothering dreams you too could pace
Behind the wagon that we flung him in,
And watch the white eyes writhing in his face,
His hanging face, like a devil's sick of sin;
If you could hear, at every jolt, the blood
Come gargling from the froth-corrupted lungs...
My friend, you would not tell with such high zest
To children ardent for some desperate glory,
The old Lie: Dulce et decorum est / Pro patria mori.*

The Dismantling of Martial Glory:

Composed while recovering from shell shock at Craiglockhart War Hospital under Siegfried Sassoon's mentorship, Owen directly addresses civilian propagandists (such as Jessie Pope) who urged young boys to enlist.

By describing the grotesque physical agony of a soldier dying of fluid-choked lungs, Owen strips away all classical romance from warfare. The Latin quote from the Roman poet Horace—*"It is sweet and fitting to die for one's fatherland"*—is exposed as an unforgivable lie.

1. "Why did the German high command fail to exploit the four-mile gap opened by the chlorine gas cloud on 22 April 1915? What does this reveal about military skepticism toward technological weapons?"
2. "How does Owen's visceral medical imagery of gas suffocation dismantle centuries of classical and Victorian heroic tradition?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 15-minute coach transit south-west to Sanctuary Wood (Hill 62) along the Meenseweg.

THE BITTER IRONY OF "SANCTUARY"

"In late 1914, British soldiers retreating from First Ypres found shelter in this dense woodland and gratefully named it 'Sanctuary Wood'. The name became a bitter, cruel irony. By June 1916, during the Battle of Mount Sorrel, German artillery rained over 100,000 high-explosive shells onto Hill 62 in a matter of hours, splintering every tree into jagged stumps and churning the forest floor into a moonscape of craters. The farmer who owned this land, the Schier family, preserved this section of frontline trenches exactly as it lay in 1918, refusing to fill the craters or flatten the parapets. As pupils walk through these unpaved, mud-slicked trenches, point out the original rusted corrugated iron revetments, the flooded sump pits, and the deep shell holes that demonstrate why survival on the Western Front was largely a matter of chance."

LIVING CONDITIONS IN THE FRONTLINE

Men spent 4–6 days in frontline firebays without sleep, washing, or warm rations. Infested with body lice that transmitted trench fever, plagued by bold trench rats feeding on unburied corpses, and standing in icy water that induced crippling **trench foot**, soldiers endured relentless physical misery alongside artillery terror.

HILL 62 STRATEGIC VANTAGE

Hill 62 rises barely 62 metres above sea level, yet in this low terrain, that modest elevation afforded optical dominance over the approaches to Ypres. The Canadian counter-attack on 13 June 1916 recaptured the ridge in a torrential downpour, suffering 8,430 casualties to deny German artillery forward observation.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **Original Corrugated Iron Sheet Revetments:** Rusted British iron and timber retaining walls surviving in the soil since 1918.
- **Mud & Sump Drainage Channels:** Notice how water collects immediately in low firebays, demonstrating why duckboards were essential.
- **Preserved Splintered Tree Stumps:** Fossilized oak and beech tree bases blasted apart by high-explosive shellfire.
- **Forward Sap Entrances:** Shallow forward trenches leading out towards No Man's Land for listening posts and nighttime wiring parties.

TOUR LEADER FIELD DIRECTIVE: MUD TERRAIN EXPERIENCE

Warn pupils regarding slick mud and uneven wooden steps. Have students feel the heavy clay underfoot before assembling for Isaac Rosenberg's poem on the facing page.

Break of Day in the Trenches · ISAAC ROSENBERG (KILLED IN ACTION 1 APRIL 1918, AGE 27)



*The darkness crumbles away.
It is the same old druid Time as ever,
Only a live thing leaps my hand,
A queer sardonic rat,
As I pull the parapet's poppy
To stick behind my ear.
Droll rat, they would shoot you if they knew
Your cosmopolitan sympathies,
Now you have touched this English hand
You will have the same chance to touch
A German one, though the thought
Would make you shudder, perhaps...
What do you see in our eyes
At the shrieking iron and flame
Hurled through still heavens?
What quaver—what heart ague has stunned you,
Leaping on the sinister wire?*

The Sardonic Rat as Universal Observer:

Rosenberg, an impoverished Jewish private and gifted Slade painter from London's East End, eschewed both patriotic posturing and self-pity.

By depicting a trench rat roaming freely between British and German barbed wire, Rosenberg exposes the grotesque absurdity of the war: vermin enjoy total freedom of movement and international brotherhood, while civilized European men crouch in mud condemned to slaughter each other.

1. "Why does Isaac Rosenberg select a 'queer sardonic rat' as the central observer of the battlefield rather than a heroic comrade or general? What does this say about the human condition in the trenches?"
2. "How does walking through authentic, unpaved muddy trenches at Sanctuary Wood alter our historical perception compared to looking at clean diagrams in a revision textbook?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 15-minute coach transit into central Ypres for supervised supermarket lunch stop (Aldi) before afternoon cemeteries.

THE GREAT CITY OF THE SILENT

"We are standing in Tyne Cot, the largest Commonwealth war cemetery in the world. Spread across this gentle slope lie **11,961 soldiers** of the British Empire. Look closely at the headstones: an astonishing **8,369 of them—nearly 70%—are unidentified**, marked only with Kipling's words: *'A Soldier of the Great War — Known unto God.'* This ground was captured by the Australian 3rd Division on 4 October 1917 during the Battle of Broodseinde. Notice the massive Cross of Sacrifice standing in the centre: architect Sir Herbert Baker deliberately encased a captured German reinforced concrete pillbox inside its stone base, cutting an aperture so the machine-gun firing slit remains visible beneath the cross. At the rear, the semi-circular Memorial to the Missing bears the carved names of **34,984 soldiers** who vanished in the mud of the Salient between August 1917 and the Armistice."



Tyne Cot Cemetery on the Passchendaele slope: The Great Cross of Sacrifice built over a German machine-gun pillbox, with 12,000 Portland headstones.

BAKER'S CLASSICAL LANDSCAPE DESIGN

Architect Sir Herbert Baker designed Tyne Cot as a classical terraced city. Flint stones from English chalk downs were embedded in the boundary walls to evoke English church masonry. The inner cluster preserves original wartime battlefield burials; outer arcs were concentrated postwar.

LOCAL PARISH SEARCH: PANELS 88–90

Lead pupils along the rear memorial wall to **Panels 88–90 (Hampshire Regiment)** to locate our three parish boys: **Pte. Sydney Muckett** (Menin Road, age 21), **Pte. Arthur Rye** (Polygon Wood, age 21), and **L/Cpl. Archibald Ward** (Gheluwe, age 23).

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **The German Pillbox Aperture:** Walk behind the Cross of Sacrifice to look through the concrete slit where German gunners fired.
- **Disordered Cluster of Field Graves:** Compare the chaotic, non-linear headstones near the central pillbox with the neat postwar outer rows.
- **Panels 88–90 (Hampshire Regiment):** Locate our local parish names on the rear memorial wall.
- **Victoria Cross Graves:** Locate the graves of Capt. Clarence Smith Jeffries VC (40th Australian Bn) and Sgt. Lewis McGee VC.

TOUR LEADER FIELD DIRECTIVE: MEMORIAL WALL SEARCH

Guide students along the curving apse to Panels 88–90. Have them record the names before assembling at the central Cross for Laurence Binyon's ode on the facing page.

For the Fallen • LAURENCE BINYON (WRITTEN SEPTEMBER 1914)



*With proud thanksgiving, a mother for her children,
England mourns for her dead across the sea.
Flesh of her flesh they were, spirit of her spirit,
Fallen in the cause of the free.*

*They went with songs to the battle, they were young,
Straight of limb, true of eye, steady and aglow.
They were staunch to the end against odds uncounted;
They fell with their faces to the foe.*

*They shall grow not old, as we that are left grow old:
Age shall not weary them, nor the years condemn.
At the going down of the sun and in the morning
We will remember them.*

*As the stars that shall be bright when we are dust,
Moving in marches upon the heavenly plain;
As the stars that are starry in the time of our darkness,
To the end, to the end, they remain.*

From the British Museum to Global Remembrance:

Sitting on the cliffs of North Cornwall in the opening weeks of the war, Binyon—an assistant keeper of prints at the British Museum too old for military service—composed these verses in response to the retreat from Mons.

The fourth stanza, known as 'The Ode of Remembrance', has become the universal liturgy recited at Remembrance Day ceremonies, military funerals, and nightly at the Menin Gate. Standing among 12,000 graves at Tyne Cot, its solemn cadence transforms individual grief into eternal collective reverence.

1. "Why did Sir Herbert Baker choose to incorporate a captured enemy pillbox directly into the foundation of the Cross of Sacrifice rather than bulldozing it away? What symbolic message does this convey?"
2. "What does the overwhelming proportion of unknown dead (nearly 70%) at Tyne Cot reveal about the physical nature of high-explosive artillery warfare during the Third Battle of Ypres?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 20-minute coach transit south-west around Ypres to Lijssenthoek Military Cemetery near Poperinge.

THE HOSPITAL CITY IN THE HOP FIELDS

"We have moved behind the frontline into the peaceful hop fields of Lijssenthoek. During the war, this was the site of the largest Casualty Clearing Station (CCS) hospital complex in the Salient, housing British 44 CCS, 10 CCS, and later French field hospitals. Positioned directly alongside the Ypres-Poperinge-Hazebrouck railway line, over **300,000 wounded men** passed through this hospital hub. Motor ambulances rushed the severely wounded here from frontline dressing stations. Surgeons operated around the clock in canvas marquees and wooden huts, performing emergency amputations and abdominal surgery before loading stabilized patients onto 30-carriage hospital trains bound for base hospitals on the coast. The **10,755 graves** surrounding us are the men who could not be saved."



Mobile Field Radiology (1917): X-ray van triaging casualties outside hospital tent.

MODERN TRAUMA MEDICINE

Surgeons pioneered the **Carrel-Dakin technique**, continuously irrigating deep shrapnel wounds with sodium hypochlorite antiseptic solution to prevent fatal gas gangrene.

THOMAS SPLINT & TRANSFUSIONS

The **Thomas Splint** (1916) pulled compound femur mortality down from 80% to under 20%. Mobile units enabled citrated whole blood transfusions at the operating table.

CASE STUDY: STAFF NURSE NELLIE SPINDLER

Locate **Plot XVI. A. 3** to find 26-year-old Staff Nurse Nellie Spindler (QAIMNS). Operating on casualties on 21 August 1917, a 210mm German shell struck her marquee. She is the **only woman buried among over 10,000 men** here.

TRIPARTITE TRIAGE PROTOCOL

Arriving stretcher cases were sorted into three stark categories:

- **Walking Wounded:** Patched and returned to unit.
- **Immediate Surgery:** Abdominal & chest cases with hope.
- **Moribund:** Comfort tents with palliative morphine.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **Grave of Staff Nurse Nellie Spindler (Plot XVI. A. 3):** Notice the QAIMNS badge and tributes at her headstone.
- **The Visitor Centre Casualty Timeline:** Glass timeline wall correlating daily burials with major offensive peaks.
- **Old Railway Siding Alignment:** Trace the wartime trackbed where hospital trains pulled up directly beside tents.
- **Allied & Enemy Plots:** Observe French, Belgian, Chinese Labour Corps, and German prisoners buried together.

1. "Why were Casualty Clearing Stations positioned along railway spurs just outside field artillery range rather than safe on the coast? What medical gamble did this represent?"

2. "How does the burial of Staff Nurse Nellie Spindler challenge traditional school textbook narratives concerning gender roles on the Western Front?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 20-minute coach transit east to Passchendaele 1917 Memorial Museum in Zonnebeke Chateau.

THE SUBTERRANEAN LABYRINTH OF ZONNEBEKE

"Beneath the grounds of Zonnebeke Chateau, we descend into an authentic, full-scale reconstruction of a British underground dugout complex built 20 feet beneath the surface. As high-explosive artillery fire obliterated every tree, trench, and building above ground in 1917, armies burrowed into the damp clay to survive. In these cramped timber galleries, over 200 men lived like moles in cold, airless conditions for weeks on end. Notice the narrow bunk beds stacked three high, the pump sumps struggling against groundwater, and the candlebox air tests: if a candle flame flickered out from lack of oxygen, men knew carbon dioxide was rising and had to crank manual ventilation fans to survive. Outside, the museum's reconstructed British and German trench systems offer pupils a direct, side-by-side physical comparison of opposing defensive philosophies."



Passchendaele Dugout: 20-ft subterranean timber galleries.



Passchendaele Mud (1917): Six bearers hauling a wounded soldier.

FAILURE OF ARTILLERY AT THIRD YPRES

Haig's offensive opened with 4.5 million shells fired onto a narrow front. Rather than destroying pillboxes, the barrage shattered delicate drainage dykes just as heavy autumn rains broke, turning the battlefield into a lethal swamp.

STRETCHER BEARING IN THE MUD

Moving a single casualty through Passchendaele mud required relays of **six to eight bearers** taking up to six hours per mile. Slipping off duckboards risked drowning beneath heavy wool kit.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **Subterranean Timber Framing:** Touch the heavy wooden baulks holding back tons of wet Flemish clay inside the dugout gallery.
- **Dugout Regimental Aid Post:** Observe the underground triage station with stretchers, morphine bottles, and surgical instruments.
- **Comparative Trench Construction:** Contrast the British deep sandbag trench with the German reinforced concrete pillbox network.
- **Original German A-Frames:** View original preserved artifacts in the museum galleries showing captured field equipment.

1. "How did subterranean dugout systems alter the psychological endurance of troops subjected to relentless week-long artillery bombardments?"
2. "Was Field Marshal Haig justified in continuing the Passchendaele offensive into November 1917 after the weather and drainage dykes broke, or did it represent operational blindness?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** 15-minute coach transit into central Ypres for evening meal and Menin Gate Last Post ceremony (arrive 19:20).

THE GREAT HALL OF MEMORY

"We are standing beneath the triumphal barrel-vaulted arch of the Menin Gate, designed by Sir Reginald Blomfield and unveiled in 1927. Through this very portal in the ancient ramparts, hundreds of thousands of British and Commonwealth soldiers marched out along the Menin Road towards the frontline trenches—many never to return. Carved into the Portland stone walls are the names of **54,395 Commonwealth soldiers** who died in the Ypres Salient before 16 August 1917 and have no known grave. When Blomfield designed the memorial, he believed the vast arch could accommodate every missing man; to the horror of the Imperial War Graves Commission, space ran out, forcing the remaining 34,984 names of later casualties to be carved at Tyne Cot. Every evening at exactly 20:00, the local volunteer Fire Brigade buglers sound the Last Post in solemn gratitude. Tonight, our school laying party lays our official wreath."



The Menin Gate Memorial on the eastern ramparts of Ypres: Blomfield's classical triumphal arch inscribed with 54,000 names of the missing.

LOCAL PARISH SEARCH: PANEL 35

Lead pupils along the south interior staircase to **Panel 35 (Hampshire Regiment)**. Here are carved the names of two young men from our home parish: **Pte. Thomas Franklin** (age 23, killed during Second Ypres) and **Pte. William Ayling** (age 20, killed by a trench mortar at Potijze). Have designated pupils hold our wreath reverently until 19:55.

CEREMONY CONDUCT & SILENCE PROTOCOL

The Last Post ceremony attracts thousands of international pilgrims. Pupils assemble on the north pavement by 19:20. Instruct pupils that absolute silence must be observed from 19:55 until bugles conclude. All heads uncovered, phones silent, and eyes directed towards the central vault.

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **Panel 35 (Hampshire Regiment):** Trace the carved names of our parish boys Thomas Franklin and William Ayling.
- **The Couchant Lion Statues:** The sculpted British lions guarding the eastern and western facades looking toward the battlefields.
- **1940 Shrapnel & Bullet Scars:** Examine the stone pillars for bullet damage sustained during the May 1940 British rearguard stand.
- **Acoustic Vault Resonance:** Listen to the extraordinary reverberation of the bugle notes beneath the 130-foot stone arch.

TOUR LEADER FIELD DIRECTIVE: WREATH LAYING ASSEMBLY

At 19:45, escort the two student wreath bearers to the inner police barrier. Accompanying staff supervise pupil lines on the pavement. Review Sassoon's anti-monument critique on the facing page during transit.

On Passing the New Menin Gate • SIEGFRIED SASSOON (WRITTEN 1927)



*Who will remember, passing through this Gate,
The unheroic Dead who fed the guns?
Who shall absolve the foulness of their fate,—
Those doomed, conscripted, unvictorious ones?
Crudely renewed, the Salient holds its own.
Paid are its dim defenders by this pomp;
Paid, with a pile of peace-complacent stone
To gym-cote hundreds and the dead who romp
In shallow waters.*

*Here was the world's worst wound. And here with pride
'Their name liveth for evermore' the Gateway claims.
Was ever an immolation so belied
As these intolerably nameless names?
Well might the Dead who struggled in the slime
Rise and deride this sepulchre of crime.*

The Anti-Monument Critique:

Attending the opening of the Menin Gate in July 1927, decorated frontline veteran Siegfried Sassoon MC was appalled by what he saw as imperial hypocrisy and smug complacency.

He fiercely condemned Blomfield's triumphal arch as a "sepulchre of crime", arguing that grandiose classical stone sanitized the horrifying physical reality of conscripted youths ground to pieces in the Flanders mud.

ARCHIVAL FIELDWORK DISCOVERY: 2ND LT. ERNEST EDWARD CRUMMACK MC, DCM

1/5th & 6th Bn York & Lancaster Regt • Direct Ancestry of our School Fieldwork Community

[PRIMARY ARCHIVE LINK](#)



2nd Lt. E. E.
Crummack
MC, DCM (1885–
1958)

During our department's archival research ahead of this expedition, pupils reconstructed the remarkable frontline service of **2nd Lieutenant Ernest Edward Crummack MC, DCM**—direct Great War ancestor of a pupil in our school group. Enlisting as a Private in 1914, Ernest earned the Distinguished Conduct Medal on the Somme in 1916 for crawling through machine-gun fire to rescue wounded comrades under fire, before receiving an officer's commission and winning the Military Cross in 1918 leading troops across the Canal du Nord.

Surviving interwar family postcards confirm that Ernest made a personal pilgrimage in the 1930s back to France and Flanders, visiting this very **Menin Gate** and staying at the adjacent Hôtel Ypriana. Standing beneath these vaulted arches today, our pupils trace not merely abstract national commemoration, but authentic, living family heritage.

1. "Why was Siegfried Sassoon so bitterly enraged by Blomfield's classical arch, dismissing it as a 'sepulchre of crime'? Does discovering that veterans like 2nd Lt. Crummack returned here on personal pilgrimage in the 1930s complicate Sassoon's critique?"
2. "What is the cultural and moral significance of the town of Ypres maintaining the Last Post ceremony every single evening for nearly a century?"

→ **Transit Guidance:** Dismiss party to coach at Lille Gate coach bays; 15-minute coach transit to Peace Village Base Camp for night rest.



Ypres Cloth Hall: Rebuilt stone-by-stone from medieval blueprints (1928–1967).



Talbot House ('Toc H'), Poperinge: The everyman rest sanctuary for all military ranks.

STOP 11: YPRES CLOTH HALL & GROTE MARKT (CIVIC REBIRTH)

In 1914, Ypres' 13th-century Gothic Cloth Hall was reduced to charred ruins by German incendiary shells. Winston Churchill passionately argued that the entire ruined city should be preserved in perpetuity as a sacred British memorial. The Belgian citizens fiercely rejected this, choosing to rebuild their city stone by stone from original medieval architectural blueprints in an epic 50-year restoration. Notice the blend of original scorched stones and reconstructed limestone.

STOP 12: TALBOT HOUSE ("TOC H"), POPERINGE — THE EVERYMAN SANCTUARY

"In late 1915, Army Chaplain Rev. Philip 'Tubby' Clayton opened this four-story townhouse as a rest house for soldiers in Poperinge ('Pop'), the bustling railhead six miles behind the front. Clayton established an extraordinary, revolutionary rule: *'All rank abandon ye who enter here.'* Inside, generals and teenage privates drank tea together, played piano, read books in the peaceful garden, and checked their weapons at the door. Up in the attic hop-loft, Tubby built a chapel where a simple carpenter's workbench served as the altar. In an army strictly segregated by class and military discipline, Talbot House provided humanity, laughter, and spiritual refuge."

4 PHYSICAL FORENSIC LOOK-FORS ON SITE

- **The Hop-Loft Chapel:** Climb to the top attic to inspect the carpenter's workbench altar and illuminated prayer texts.
- **Tubby Clayton's Desk & Library:** View the handwritten sign-in ledger where soldiers checked in their caps and revolver holsters.
- **The Peaceful Walled Garden:** The quiet oasis where men sat in deckchairs escaping the relentless sound of artillery.
- **Cloth Hall Scorched Masonry:** In the Grote Markt, spot the dark, fire-blackened medieval stones embedded in the restored belfry tower.

→ **Transit Guidance:** 10-minute walk through Poperinge town centre to the Town Hall Courtyard Execution Cells.

STOP 13: POPERINGE TOWN HALL EXECUTION CELLS & SHOT AT DAWN

In the quiet courtyard of Poperinge Town Hall stand the preserved execution cells and wooden post where soldiers condemned by British Court Martial were executed by firing squad at dawn. Across the war, **306 British and Commonwealth soldiers** were shot for desertion or cowardice. Most were young men suffering from severe combat fatigue and shell shock (PTSD), then unrecognised by military authorities as a legitimate psychiatric illness. In 2006, the British government passed a historic statutory pardon for all 306 men, formally acknowledging their tragic plight.

The Soldier • RUPERT BROOKE (WRITTEN 1914 — THE GEORGIAN IDEAL)



*If I should die, think only this of me:
That there's some corner of a foreign field
That is for ever England. There shall be
In that rich earth a richer dust concealed;
A dust whom England bore, shaped, made aware,
Gave, once, her flowers to love, her ways to roam;
A body of England's, breathing English air,
Washed by the rivers, blest by suns of home.*

*And think, this heart, all evil shed away,
A pulse in the eternal mind, no less
Gives somewhere back the thoughts by England given;
Her sights and sounds; dreams happy as her day;
And laughter, learnt of friends; and gentleness,
In hearts at peace, under an English heaven.*

The 1914 Romantic Arc vs 1917 Reality:

Rupert Brooke captured the innocent, patriotic idealism of August 1914 before the mechanized slaughter of the Western Front shattered Victorian illusions.

Have pupils contrast Brooke's gentle, pastoral "English heaven" with Wilfred Owen's choking "green sea" at Vancouver Corner, Isaac Rosenberg's sardonic rat, and Siegfried Sassoon's fury at the Menin Gate.

1. "Was the execution of soldiers suffering from acute shell shock a military necessity to maintain combat discipline, or a tragic failure of medical compassion?"
2. "How did the collective memory of the Great War shift from Rupert Brooke's romantic sacrifice (1914) to Wilfred Owen and Siegfried Sassoon's bitter disillusionment (1917–1927)?"

→ **Expedition Conclusion:** Depart Poperinge at 14:30 for Calais Eurotunnel (17:50 crossing); return to school base approx. 20:00.

1. THE TRENCH SYSTEM & THE FLEMISH ENVIRONMENT (PHYSICAL TERRAIN)

- **Front Line Trench:** Firing trench closest to the enemy (60–300m away); built in continuous zig-zags with firebays to contain shell bursts and prevent enfilade machine-gun fire.
- **Support Trench (80–100m behind front):** Housed secondary garrisons and reserve ammunition to reinforce the front line quickly during enemy assaults.
- **Reserve Trench (300–500m behind front):** Held battalions for counter-attacks; provided temporary relief from immediate small-arms fire.
- **Communication Trenches:** Deep zigzag channels connecting all lines; enabled movement of troops, fresh rations, ammunition, and stretchers under cover.
- **Traverses & Firestep:** Right-angle earth baffles stopping shrapnel spreading down bays; raised ledge allowing riflemen to fire over the parapet.
- **Parapet & Parados:** Sandbag breastworks; parapet shielded firing men to the front; parados prevented soldiers being hit from behind by shell bursts.
- **Flemish Blue Clay & Dykes:** Impermeable water-logged clay; artillery destroyed medieval drainage systems, causing duckboards to submerge in liquid mud.
- **Dugouts & Saps:** Protective underground shelters cut into trench walls; saps were narrow listening posts dug forward into No Man's Land.

2. ILL-HEALTH, INFECTION & BATTLE INJURIES (CAUSES, SYMPTOMS & SOLUTIONS)

- **Trench Foot:** Painful fungal rotting of feet caused by prolonged standing in freezing water/mud; led to gangrene and amputation. *Prevention:* Whale oil rubs, changing into clean dry socks twice daily, drainage sumps, and buddy checks.
- **Trench Fever:** Debilitating flu-like pyrexia with severe joint and leg pains, transmitted by body lice living in uniforms. *Prevention:* Delousing stations, hot showers, and portable steam-fumigation vans.
- **Shell Shock (NYDN):** Acute psychological trauma caused by relentless artillery bombardment; caused tremors, nightmares, mutism, and paralysis. Labeled 'Not Yet Diagnosed Nervous'; treated at Craiglockhart by rest and psychotherapy.
- **High-Explosive Shells & Shrapnel:** Exploding steel cases scattering jagged balls/fragments, responsible for 58% of all Western Front wounds and compound bone fractures. The steel Brodie helmet (late 1915) cut head wound fatalities by 80%.
- **Gas Gangrene:** Rapid bacterial infection producing foul gas and destroying muscle, caused by anaerobic bacteria in heavily manured Flemish soil entering deep wounds. *Treatment:* Surgical wound debridement and Carrel-Dakin solution.
- **Tetanus (Lockjaw):** Soil bacteria causing fatal muscle spasms. Prevented by routine injections of Anti-Tetanus Serum (ATS) at Regimental Aid Posts.

3. CHEMICAL WARFARE: POISON GASES, PHYSICAL EFFECTS & RESPIRATORS

- **Chlorine Gas (First used 22 April 1915, Second Ypres):** Greenish-yellow cloud that stripped bronchial linings; death by suffocating internal fluid. First neutralized by urine-soaked cloths (ammonia neutralized acid).
- **Phosgene Gas (First used Dec 1915 at Boezinge):** Colorless gas smelling of musty hay; six times deadlier than chlorine. Symptoms were delayed 24–48 hours, causing sudden fatal lung drowning.
- **Mustard Gas (First used July 1917, Third Ypres):** Oily liquid agent causing internal lung blisters, external chemical skin burns, and blindness. Burned through uniforms and contaminated trenches for days.
- **Gas Helmets & Respirators:** Evolved from cotton-wool pads to Hypo/Phenate flannel helmets, and the Small Box Respirator (1916) with charcoal filters, reducing gas fatalities to under 3% of casualties.

Exam Focus: "Describe two features of..." [4 marks] — 1 mark for each feature + 1 mark for valid supporting historical detail.

Continued on Page 24

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1. THE CHAIN OF EVACUATION & MEDICAL TRANSPORT (ROUTE FROM TRENCHES TO COAST)

- **Stretcher Bearers:** Hauled wounded from No Man's Land and firebays to RAPs under fire; only 16 bearers per battalion of 1,000 men; carried basic shell dressings and morphine.
- **Regimental Aid Post (RAP):** Located 200m behind front line in dugouts or cellars; battalion doctor performed immediate emergency first aid and bandaged wounds.
- **Advanced & Main Dressing Stations (ADS/MDS):** Located 1–2 miles back (e.g. Essex Farm); conducted initial triage, administered Anti-Tetanus Serum (ATS), and fitted Thomas Splints.
- **Casualty Clearing Station (CCS):** Major surgical hubs 7–12 miles back near railway lines (e.g. Lijssenthoek); sorted men into 3 triage groups (walking wounded, urgent surgery, moribund); performed emergency amputations to stop gangrene.
- **Base Hospitals:** Large specialist centers on the French coast (Boulogne, Étaples, Calais); long-term treatment, plastic surgery, or hospital ship transit to Britain ('Blighty').
- **Motor Ambulances:** Rapidly replaced horse-drawn wagons from Oct 1914 (British Red Cross); prevented fatal delays across shell-churned roads.
- **Ambulance Trains & Barges:** 30-coach trains carried up to 800 wounded to coastal ports; canal barges along the Yser river carried head/chest injuries smoothly without jarring shocks.
- **RAMC & FANY:** Royal Army Medical Corps grew from 9,000 to over 113,000 personnel; First Aid Nursing Yeomanry (FANY) provided frontline female ambulance drivers from 1916.

2. MEDICAL & SURGICAL INNOVATIONS (PIONEERED ON THE WESTERN FRONT)

- **The Thomas Splint (Dec 1915):** Introduced to frontline by Robert Jones; kept fractured femur straight to stop bone ends severing femoral artery; cut compound fracture mortality from 80% to under 20%.
- **Mobile X-Ray Units:** Installed in motor vans (Marie Curie's 'Petites Curies'); located shrapnel and bullet fragments before surgery to prevent fatal sepsis and gangrene.
- **Carrel-Dakin Method (1915):** Continuous chemical irrigation of open wounds with sodium hypochlorite antiseptic solution via rubber tubes before sewing.
- **Blood Transfusions & Blood Banks:** Richard Lewisohn (1915) found adding sodium citrate stopped clotting; Oswald Hope Robertson (1917) created the first refrigerated citrate-glucose blood bank for Cambrai.
- **Plastic & Facial Surgery:** Harold Gillies at Queen's Hospital, Sidcup (1917) pioneered pedicle skin tube grafting to reconstruct shattered jaws and faces.
- **Brain Surgery:** Harvey Cushing used local anesthetic to prevent brain swelling and magnetized probes to extract shrapnel, cutting mortality from 50% to 29%.

3. EDEXCEL PAPER 1 EXAM STRATEGY: "DESCRIBE TWO FEATURES OF..." [4 MARKS]

Official Marking Formula: Q1(a) [2m] + Q1(b) [2m]. For each question: State **one valid feature** (1 mark) + Add **specific supporting historical evidence/detail** (1 mark).

Practice Revision Stems: • Features of an Advanced Dressing Station • Features of the Thomas Splint • Features of blood transfusions at Cambrai • Features of underground dugouts at Zonnebeke • Features of chlorine gas attacks • Features of the Carrel-Dakin method.

THE HISTORY DEPARTMENT • PILGRIMAGE OF REMEMBRANCE

"Dedicated to the memory of the fallen of our home parish of Holy Rood and the countless thousands who lie in the quiet earth of Flanders. We will remember them."